

prototype

THE EXPERIMENTAL MUSEUM

Prototype: The Experimental Museum

Press Fact Sheet - Fall 2025

MISSION & VISION

Prototype: The Experimental Museum is a permanent destination for innovative, supersensory experiences – where art, media, and technology converge to create bold, boundary-pushing installations. Designed for curious adults, Prototype invites visitors to engage, react, and shape the future of cultural experiences. The museum offers an ever-changing landscape of interactive spaces, immersive projections, sound installations, and provocative exhibits that defy traditional museum norms.

Backed by Roto, one of North America's leading experience design and interactive media firms, Prototype is built on a foundation of technical innovation and creative risk-taking. Every installation is an experiment – designed to ignite joy, curiosity, and conversation. This is a platform for emerging creators, technologists, and audiences to test what's next.

Location: 540 Maier Place, Columbus, Ohio

Opening: 11.01.2025

Square Footage: 30,000 SF

Tickets: Advanced Ticket Purchase Required

Audience: Prototype is an adults-only museum, ages 16+

Staff: Kristal Bell, Director of Operations

Alyssa Moody, Operations Manager

Chris Cortese, Technology Manager

Creative Team: Joseph Wisne, Creative Director

Nick Braun, Creative Technology Lead

Natalie Pettit, Project Manager

INSIDE THE EXPERIMENT

- The museum appears to be the first and only “experimental museum” in the U.S. committed to the innovation of museum arts and technology itself. Prototype is meta - a museum about museums.
- One central thesis of this experimentation is to view museum experience development like film production—a single group of experienced professionals, each with unique creative and technical expertise, collaborating closely from early concept through final installation under the direction of visionary leadership. (Editor's note: This is unconventional, as most museums are planned strategically by one party, often the museum itself, designed by another party, usually an exhibit design or architecture firm, and then built by a third party “fabricator” and an assortment of unrelated specialists, like software programmers. This slows down innovation, increases costs, and works against the achievement of a cohesive vision.)
- Another central thesis of Prototype's experimental model is to emphasize the value of iteration. No exhibit is ever “final,” as observations of and feedback from users steers the direction of new ideas and updates. Experimentation is the mission.
- The concept for Prototype was in incubation for about two years before being “green lit” for full funding and production. Smaller versions of the museum were studied for a site in Franklinton and in Dublin, before settling on the current model.
- Once green lit, Prototype was fully designed, the facility constructed, exhibits fabricated, complex AV systems engineered, and content programmed and animated, all inside 18 months (late April 2024 through October 2025).
- Prototype: The Experimental Museum occupies just under 30,000 square feet of total interior space, with 85% devoted to experiences—this is nearly twice the average ratio of museum exhibits to building size (typically 40% to 50%). This efficiency keeps operating and staffing costs manageable while focusing primarily on earning high levels of guest satisfaction.

- Hourly attendance is expected to be capped at 80 per hour, regardless of demand, ensuring that Prototype never feels “crowded” and most visitors can get to most of the experiences with little or no waiting.
- Another innovation of Prototype is to guide visitors on a semi-sequential experience that builds, like a film, from a bold introduction (Stage 1) through a series of increasingly immersive and theatrical stages (2-5), before climaxing in an theater “finale” - Stage 6, the largest immersive space in Prototype.
- Each experience in Prototype is an active experiment, each with their own individual purpose and motivations (often several at once). Most serve as a “platform” which Prototype plans to utilize for effectively collaborating with outside artists, iterating on existing ideas and installing brand new ones as our insights and partnerships expand.
- Five (5) different film companies participated in creating content for various Prototype exhibits, including the best talent in Central Ohio, supplemented by motion graphic artists from Spain, Germany, Poland, Canada and the UK.
- The Prototype creative team included the work of no fewer than nine (9) accomplished musicians and composers to create various soundtracks and audio features built into the many interactives.
- These audio experiences are supported by an innovative technical arrangement of self-amplified “monitor” speakers normally found only in high-end sound recording and engineering studios. More than 75 individual high-resolution monitors are used throughout the exhibits, while the Stage 6 theater employs 36 cinematic loudspeakers capable of rendering up to 12 independent channels of surround sound.
- The Stage 6 theater is double-walled (a shell within a shell), so its exceptionally deep and rich sound system can be contained within the enclosure and not unduly spill out into other adjacent spaces.
- The Stage 6 theater possesses a sophisticated built-in theatrical lighting system, including fourteen moving head “concert” fixtures, capable of producing virtually any look, from a quiet darkened screening room to a full-on rave.
- The Stage 6 projection screen is 150 feet wide and 17 feet tall, requiring six (6) 30,000 lumen projectors each weighing more than 250 lbs. and collectively generating 48 million pixels of video (20,000 by 2,400 pixels) -- that’s 4 times the typical IMAX digital screen and more than 20 times the resolution of the average AMC movie.
- Some two-dozen organizations and individuals were consulted for the purpose of shaping the original Prototype concept, including museum leaders from around the country, as well as local artists and arts organizations. Prototype opened with three (3) robust arts partner projects (BalletMet, Champaign Aviation Museum and Meimage Taiwan), with more in the pipeline.
- The technology backbone for Prototype is an advanced network of 40 high-end servers and more than 100 PCs and digital appliances, requiring an estimated 20 miles of high-speed cabling throughout the building. This system allows for remote updates and rapid reconfiguration for any exhibit or platform.
- The creative design technology found throughout Prototype include Unity and Unreal Engine, the dominant platforms for most AAA video games, TouchDesigner and various exotic plug-ins, motion graphics tools like Houdini, Blender and Cinema4D, as well as custom code developed by the engineers at Roto.
- Roto employs the largest and deepest design technology team in the museum field, responsible for more than 100 notable museum exhibit projects just in the last 7 years. Some that Central Ohio residents may recognize include “Cleveland Creates” at Great Lakes Science Center, “Shaping Our City,” “Space Exploration,” “Science Interactives,” and “Cincinnati In Motion” at Cincinnati Museum Center, The Ohio Constitution exhibit at the Ohio Statehouse Museum, “Champion of Sports” at Ohio History Connection, and numerous interactive and interpretive elements from “Adventure Cove” and “Heart of Africa” at the Columbus Zoo & Aquarium. Farther afield, Roto has signature projects from Florida to Calgary, Los Angeles to New York City, where they are currently installing a multi-million-dollar attraction in Times Square.

